

THE HACHETTE BOOK OF INDIAN DETECTIVE FICTION
Edited by Tarun K. Saint
HACHETTE
₹1,299; 848 pages

BOOKS

WITH OUR OWN DESI SLEUTHS

Indian detective fiction gets its due in this massive, two-volume compilation from Hachette

In the introduction to the two-volume *The Hachette Book of Indian Detective Fiction*, editor Tarun K. Saint writes that the project's intention is "further reinvention" of the genre "in a subcontinental context with cutting-edge work".

To that effect, only a handful of entries successfully satisfy this tall order, the standout being Sumit Bardhan's 'Death of an Actress' that serves a bizarre but satisfying twist to the contemporary private detective story.

The 36 stories across 900 pages can be graphed across an X-Y plane: amateur and police detectives on the X axis, historical and futuristic fiction on the Y axis. Mixed-genre and experimental stories hover somewhere in the centre. The best among these

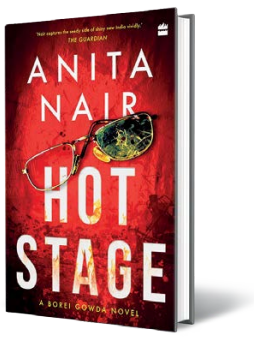
BOOKS

GOWDA KNOWS

Hot Stage, the third book in **Anita Nair's** Inspector Gowda mystery series, is here

If you're a Sherlock Holmes fan, you'll remember the passage from 'The Greek Interpreter' where Sherlock describes his elder brother Mycroft—supposedly, a greater deductive mind. But the man had "no ambition and no energy" to follow up on the leads his great mind opened up. This Sherlock/ Mycroft distinction is also, in a way, the difference between detective and police work. The latter is a considerably larger skill-set that goes beyond the cold precision of 'pure' deductive reasoning.

Anita Nair's Inspector Gowda is a great example of this distinction and also of character growth within a series. Ever since we first met him in *Cut Like Wound* (2012), he has been a talented investigator—but by the end of the third book, *Hot Stage*, we realise that he has become much more. He has learned to be more restrained in high-pressure situations, less likely to take the bait when a vengeful senior officer is trying to get a rise out of him. In *Hot Stage*, the murder before him is that of Professor Mudgood, a rationalist and anti-superstition activist who draws the ire of right-wing Hindu groups in Bangalore (clearly inspired by the murder of Narendra Dabholkar in 2013). Everybody thinks the killing is politically motivated, but Gowda, astute as ever, unravels a larger conspiracy.



HOT STAGE
A Borei Gowda novel
by Anita Nair
HARPERCOLLINS
₹499; 444 pages

The novel's three-dimensional characters are its biggest strength. The righteous Prof. Mudgood, we are shown, was a petty and mischievous man who was deeply patriarchal. Gowda's junior Santosh is a bright-eyed chap who idolises Gowda and is eager to learn but, through this overenthusiasm, ends up placing him and his team into trouble.

Hot Stage and its predecessors are books that are extremely well-versed in the science of footprints, blood spatters and gunshot residue et al. This does not mean that Nair underestimates the value of good, old-fashioned, observational investigation, things like noticing the body language shift in a room full of potential suspects.

Without giving away too much, I will say this—I enjoyed how it tied in with concerns longtime citizens have about Bangalore, about its lopsided development, and its vanishing civic spaces. *Hot Stage* confirms the now 51-year-old Borei Gowda as arguably the most interesting sleuth in Indian literature, and certainly the most resilient one. ■

–Aditya Mani Jha